Anti-Pattern Spotter

Tick the anti-patterns you recognise, vote on the ones that hurt most, and pick a tool to tackle each.

Reflect & Improve · Common Anti-Patterns · Spot · Vote · Act · See the Anti-Pattern Catalogue

LEGEND

- Dot = Vote (3 per person)
- Tick = We recognise this

HOW TO USE IT

1. **Spot** Tick every symptom you recognise, alone and in silence.
2. **Vote** Three dots each on the ones that hurt most.
3. **Act** Take the top three into the table below.

Events

- [ ] Daily sync is a status report
- [ ] Same issues at every retro
- [ ] Review is a one-way demo
- [ ] Planning has no goal

Backlog

- [ ] Stories are technical tasks
- [ ] Epics have no outcome
- [ ] Backlog graveyard
- [ ] Everything is top priority

Flow

- [ ] Too much work in progress
- [ ] Blocked work goes unnoticed
- [ ] “Done” means dev done
- [ ] Unplanned work wrecks plans

Teams & roles

- [ ] Product owner unavailable
- [ ] SM is the team's secretary
- [ ] Unclear decision rights
- [ ] Quiet voices go unheard

Multi-team

- [ ] Teams wait on each other
- [ ] Cross-team sync is status
- [ ] Top-down big-room planning
- [ ] One team owns too much

Leadership

- [ ] Too many initiatives
- [ ] Change announced, not led
- [ ] Annual funding only
- [ ] Agile as a mandate

Metrics & reporting

- [ ] Velocity as a target
- [ ] Single-date promises
- [ ] Green until suddenly red
- [ ] Individuals measured by tickets

Our Own

- [ ] _____
- [ ] _____
- [ ] _____
- [ ] _____

1 Our Top Three

WHY HERE? WHAT WILL WE TRY?

ANTI-PATTERN	WHY IT'S HAPPENING HERE	TOOL TO TRY	OWNER	CHECK ON

2 Next Time

- [ ] Re-run the spotter in 6–8 weeks
- [ ] Compare which ticks have gone
- [ ] Look up each symptom in the catalogue

Next session: _____

“Which of these would we be embarrassed for a new joiner to see?”

“If we fixed only one, which would make the biggest difference?”

© 2026 Eric Parker · CC BY 4.0 · eparker71.github.io/agile-ways-of-working